

Green Berets

Championed by President Kennedy, the US Special Forces, known as the Green Berets, began their service in Vietnam by training the hilltribe people in guerrilla warfare.

◀◀ BEFORE

President Kennedy valued the Green Berets for the flexibility of their response.

SMALL BEGINNINGS

The elite fighting force known as the Green Berets developed from the **Tenth Special Forces Group** established in June 1952. The unit consisted of just 10 soldiers, all, as now, volunteers.

NEW TYPES OF CONFLICT

Kennedy's belief in the efficacy of Special Forces predated his presidency. He believed Eisenhower had focused too heavily on **nuclear arms**, leaving the US ill-equipped to fight conventional conflicts of the kind Kennedy expected to face in Asia. Kennedy especially praised the Special Forces' "flexible response."

Counterinsurgency was a key policy for the Kennedy administration, and the expansion of US Special Forces to implement the strategy became a top military priority. At the time of Kennedy's inauguration in January 1961, there were three Special Forces groups in existence—the Tenth, the Seventh, and the First. These were joined by the Fifth, activated in September 1961, and the Eighth and the Third in 1963.

The right recruits

Special Forces soldiers were highly trained. In addition to satisfying tough physical demands and being qualified parachutists, potential recruits had to show they were independent thinkers with the potential to fight and survive in harsh combat conditions. The first phase of the assessment and selection procedure lasted 24 days and included a week-long field training exercise. Round-the-clock land navigation exercises, reconnaissance patrols, ambushes, raids, and an escape and evasion exercise pushed the recruits to the limits of their physical and mental endurance. In the second phase of the training, recruits received instruction in one of five specialty areas—operations and intelligence, weapons, engineering, medicine, and communications. In the third phase, they learned the basics of guerrilla warfare.